There was a difference in degree as well, with Kennedy believing even more strongly in India's role as a counterbalance and contrast to China. Even before he took office, in a campaign speech ahead of the New Hampshire primary in 1960, Kennedy had called for the noncommunist world to devote more time and attention to "the struggle between India and China for leadership of the East, for the respect of all Asia, for the opportunity to demonstrate whose way of life is the better." He had further highlighted the reason why "the outcome of this competition will vitally affect the security and standing of this Nation": if India faltered in this struggle "its role as a counter to the Red Chinese will be lost, and communism would have won its greatest bloodless victory."[153]

India was not worried about the change of administrations. As Dillon had noted to the Indian finance minister before the 1960 polls, "Whichever party won the forthcoming election would be sympathetic to continuing aid to India."[154] Indian officials, however, particularly welcomed Kennedy's victory since he was a "friend" of India, and his close advisers had "forcefully advocated" for its cause.[155]

In early 1961, Indian policymakers made the case for aid to incoming administration officials. Embassy official B. K. Nehru argued, "India, on a population basis and for compelling political reasons, had a good case for receiving 'substantially more than one-third' of total American aid." He also noted the Soviet commitment of $500 million worth of credit for India's five-year plan and consideration of another $300 million.[156] When Vice President Lyndon B. Johnson visited India in May 1961, Prime Minister Nehru also highlighted his government's challenge: "We have a politically conscious mass of people who think that they deserve everything —and they do—but India is unable to supply it." The prime minister simultaneously also emphasized the progress India was making and stressed that the trends were moving in the right direction.[157]

Indian officials were preaching to the choir. Eisenhower's policy planning director at State had feared that a new administration would be "reluctant" to put together a large foreign assistance plan.[158] This concern was misplaced. A Kennedy transition group on aid for India indeed suggested annual aid of $500 million. An administration task force to review foreign assistance led by Under Secretary of State George Ball criticized the previous administration's emphasis on military assistance, but